his horse during a polo match, Akbar healed him with ‘his holy breathings’. A year later, a mad elephant ran at Birbar during an animal fight and Akbar came charging between the two on his horse. It was the emperor’s usual courage, of course, but also ‘his . . . especial kindness’ for the brahmin poet.[17]

What was it that so attracted Akbar to Birbar? Why did he risk his own life for him, or build palaces for him in Fatehpur – an honour not accorded any other mansabdar?

Birbar was a talented poet. P.P. Sinha quotes some lovely verses by him in his biography of Akbar’s friend.[18] This, for example, would have appealed to Akbar’s mind as much as to his ear:

Toote par eekh taaki mistri gud kand karo taake le
prasad dev-devin chadaaiye
Phuti ke kapaas par raakhat hai aalam ki vaake hot
vastra kahan lo ginaaiye
Sade jab san taake svet ban kaagaz ke taapar Quran-o-
Puranh-u likhaaiye
Kahe kavi Braham suno Akbar Badshah, toote-phoote
sade taako ya bidhi saraahiye
When cane is crushed we get sugar whereof to make
sweets for the gods
When cotton flowers burst we get clothes whereof to
cover our shame
When the jute plant rots we get the paper whereon the
Quran and Puranas are written
‘Hear O Akbar Shah,’ says the poet Braham, ‘so the
broken of the world may be reformed’

Sinha also offers some examples of the apocryphal wit for which Birbar is renowned in popular culture. What decays when cooked and thrives when burnt? A brick.

Akbar was not averse to a good joke. Father Monserrate describes the emperor as friendly and accessible, but liable to become morose, for which condition he organized all kinds of entertainment, from polo matches, boxing bouts and pigeon-flying to ‘concerts, dances, conjurer’s tricks, and the jokes of his jesters, of whom he makes much’. He was as